### 15.3.4 Putting the layers together

These three layers—foundational security policies, shared operational policies, and application policies—work together to create a flexible framework for expressing a zero-trust security architecture. A single access request is assessed once using policies pulled from multiple policy stores that correspond to each layer. By applying all relevant policies across these stores, the policy engine determines the full set of conditions necessary for the decision. Foundational requirements, shared operational rules, and service-specific logic are all taken into account to produce one unified authorization decision.

This layered approach distributes policy ownership across the organization without fragmenting decision logic. Security and identity teams handle enterprise-wide requirements; functional groups like engineering, operations, or finance define shared operational rules; and product teams set the behavior of their own services. The result is an authorization system that stays consistent and enforceable while allowing the different teams to fulfill their responsibilities. It makes Zero Trust both practical and sustainable, giving each group a clear way to express its intent while making sure that every request is checked against the organization’s full set of expectations.